Current Affairs 12-10-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

Separation of Powers and Judicial Independence

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For Prelims: One Nation, One Election , Separation of powers , Directive Principle of State Policy , Article 143

For Mains: Doctrine of Separation of Powers, Checks and balances between the Legislature, Executive and Judiciary

Source: TH

Why in News?

The **Supreme Court of India** declined a proposed meeting with the **Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024,** which seeks to implement **'One Nation, One Election' (simultaneous elections).**

- The proposed interaction was called off after the judiciary and opposition members cited concerns regarding the **doctrine of the separation of powers** and the **prospect of future judicial review.**

Summary

- The Supreme Court's refusal to engage with the JPC highlights the importance of **judicial independence, constitutional propriety and separation of powers** between the Legislature and Judiciary.
- The **Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024** , including proposed **Article 82A** , seeks simultaneous Lok Sabha and State Assembly elections, with provisions for **unexpired terms and election deferment** .

What is the Doctrine of the Separation of Powers?

- **Definition & Origin:** Coined by the French philosopher **Montesquieu** in his work *The Spirit of the Laws* , the doctrine mandates the division of state power into three distinct branches: the **Executive, the Legislature, and the Judiciary** .

- The goal is to prevent the concentration of power, avoid authoritarianism, and safeguard civil liberties.

- **Indian Constitutional Scheme:** Unlike the rigid "watertight compartments" seen in the US Constitution, India follows a functional separation with a robust system of **Checks and Balances** .
  - **Article 50:** A **Directive Principle of State Policy (DPSP)** that directs the State to separate the judiciary from the executive in public services.
  - **Articles 121 & 211:** Expressly restrict Parliament and State Legislatures from discussing the conduct of judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts in the discharge of their duties.
  - **Articles 122 & 212:** Prohibit the courts from inquiring into the validity of the proceedings of the Legislature, ensuring parliamentary autonomy.
- **Basic Structure Doctrine:** In landmark judgements such as ***Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala (1973)*** **and** ***Indira Nehru Gandhi v. Raj Narain (1975)*** , the Supreme Court firmly established that the separation of powers is an inviolable part of the **Basic Structure** of the Indian Constitution, beyond the amending power of Parliament.

What are the Concerns Regarding Separation of Powers?

- **Threat of Pre-Adjudication and Bias:** The legislature's exclusive domain is drafting and enacting laws, while the judiciary's mandate is **Judicial Review (Article 13)** .
  - If sitting judges advise or discuss a bill during its drafting stage, it inherently compromises their neutrality.
  - If the same bill is later passed into law and challenged in court, those judges would face a massive conflict of interest.
- **Erosion of Judicial Independence:** The judiciary relies on public trust in its **absolute impartiality.**
  - Closed-door meetings between parliamentary panels (dominated by political representatives) and judges risk creating a perception of judicial alignment with the government's legislative agenda, damaging the credibility of the courts.
- **Bypassing Established Constitutional Channels:** The Constitution already provides a formal mechanism for the State to seek the Supreme Court's legal opinion. Under **Article 143 (Advisory Jurisdiction)** , the President can refer a question of law or public importance to the Supreme Court.
  - Bypassing this formal, transparent route for informal "study visits" undermines constitutional architecture.
- **Blurring of Institutional Silos:** While a rigid separation is not practical, involving the judiciary in the law-making process crosses a bright constitutional line.
  - It blends legislative drafting with judicial insight, leading to institutional overreach where the courts might inadvertently become co-authors of legislation.

Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024

- **Background:** India originally conducted simultaneous elections for the Lok Sabha and state assemblies between 1951 and 1967.
  - This cycle was broken due to political instability and the premature dissolution of various legislative bodies.
  - To explore restoring this system, the Union Government constituted a High-Level Committee led by former President Ram Nath Kovind in September 2023. The committee submitted its report in March 2024, recommending a phased transition to simultaneous polls.
- **About:** The **Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024, introduced in December 2024,** is the primary legal framework to implement 'One Nation, One Election' (ONOE).
  - It aims to synchronise elections for the Lok Sabha and all State Legislative Assemblies. The overarching goal is to reduce public expenditure, ease the logistical burden on security forces, and prevent governance disruptions caused by the frequent application of the **Model Code of Conduct.**
  - The current Bill strategically **excludes local bodies (Panchayats and Municipalities).**
- **Key Provisions:**
  - **Insertion of Article 82A:** Creates the overarching constitutional mechanism mandating the **Election Commission of India (ECI)** to conduct simultaneous elections for the House of the People (Lok Sabha) and all State Legislative Assemblies.
  - **The "Unexpired Term" Rule (Amending Articles 83 & 172):** If a State Assembly or the **Lok Sabha** is dissolved prematurely (e.g., due to a fallen government), mid-term elections will be held. However, the newly elected body will only serve for the remaining (unexpired) duration of the original five-year cycle, ensuring the next elections re-align nationally.
  - **Election Deferment:** Article 82A empowers the ECI to advise the President to defer a specific state assembly election in case of localized emergencies. Even if deferred, that assembly's term will **end simultaneously with the Lok Sabha.**
  - **Expanding Parliament's Purview (Amending Article 327):** Adds the phrase "conduct of simultaneous elections" to Parliament's existing powers regarding the delimitation of constituencies, granting it clearer authority over state legislature elections.

What Measures are Needed to Prevent Institutional Friction and Uphold Constitutional Integrity?

- **Utilizing Independent Legal Experts:** Instead of approaching sitting judges, parliamentary committees should rely on former judges, the **Attorney General of India (Article 76)** , the **Law Commission** , and independent constitutional scholars for legal insights on complex pending bills.
- **Strict Adherence to Constitutional Propriety:** Both Parliament and the Judiciary must actively self-regulate and respect the boundaries demarcated by the Constitution. The Supreme Court's decision to decline the recent JPC meeting serves as an excellent precedent for maintaining this distance.
- **Institutionalising Protocols for JPCs:** Parliament should frame explicit internal guidelines within the *Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business* . These rules should formally restrict parliamentary

committees from seeking informal policy discussions or "study visits" with members of the higher judiciary.

- **Invoking Formal Advisory Routes:** If constitutional clarity on a pending reform is absolutely critical to the nation's interest, the **Executive should advise the President to formally invoke Article 143,** ensuring that the Supreme Court's opinion is sought on record and through proper legal proceedings.

Conclusion

Preserving the **Doctrine of Separation of Powers** is not merely an academic exercise; it is a practical imperative to ensure that the Legislature remains supreme in lawmaking, while the Judiciary remains a fearless, independent, and unbiased arbiter of constitutional justice.

Drishti Mains Question:

The Indian Constitution does not envisage a rigid separation of powers, but rather a system of functional separation supported by checks and balances. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the doctrine of separation of powers?
It divides state functions among the **Legislature, Executive and Judiciary** and prevents concentration of power through **checks and balances** .

2. Is separation of powers part of the Basic Structure of the Indian Constitution?
Yes. The Supreme Court has recognised **separation of powers as part of the Basic Structure** , limiting Parliament’s amending power.

3. What is Article 82A proposed under the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024?
Article 82A seeks to provide the constitutional framework for **simultaneous elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies** .

4. What is the significance of Article 143?
Article 143 empowers the President to refer questions of **law or public importance** to the Supreme Court for its advisory opinion.

5. How does the ONOE Bill address premature dissolution of a legislature?
Under the proposed **unexpired-term mechanism** , a legislature elected after premature dissolution would serve only for the **remaining period of the original term** , helping restore electoral synchronisation.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/xzH2sCJsbvU**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: (2017)

1. The Election Commission of India is a five-member body.
2. Union Ministry of Home Affairs decides the election schedule for the conduct of both general elections and bye-elections.
3. Election Commission resolves the disputes relating to splits/mergers of recognised political parties.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only

(b) 2 only

(c) 2 and 3 only

(d) 3 only

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. Discuss the role of the Election Commission of India in the light of the evolution of the Model Code of Conduct. **(2022)**

Q. Simultaneous election to the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies will limit the amount of time and money spent in electioneering but it will reduce the government's accountability to the people". Discuss. **(2017)**

Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses** completed its first year, marking progress towards **self-sufficiency in pulses by 2030–31** through increased domestic production, reduced import dependence and enhanced farmers' incomes.

What are the Key Facts About the Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses?

- **About:** Launched on **11th October 2025, with an outlay of ₹11,440 crore for 2025–26** to **2030–31,** the Mission aims to achieve self-sufficiency in pulses, reduce imports and enhance farmers' incomes.
- **Production Target:** Increase pulses production to **350 lakh tonnes, productivity to 1,130 kg/ha and cultivation area to 310 lakh hectares by 2030–31** , including expansion into 35 lakh hectares of additional land.
- **Priority Crops:** Focus on **Tur, Urad and Masur,** promoting high-yielding, pest-resistant and climate-resilient varieties.
- **Seed Support:** Distribute **87.5 lakh free seed kits and 126 lakh quintals** of certified seeds over six years, supported by seed traceability through the **Seed Authentication, Traceability and Holistic Inventory (SATHI) portal.**
- **Assured Procurement:** The **National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India (NAFED)** and **National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India (NCCF)** will undertake 100% procurement of Tur, Urad and Masur at Minimum Support Price (MSP) from registered and willing farmers in participating States under the **Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay Sanrakshan Abhiyan (PM-AASHA)** for four years (2025–26 to 2028–29).
- **Cluster-Based Approach:** Promote region-specific interventions **across 489 districts, including cultivation in rice-fallow areas,** intercropping and crop diversification.
- **Processing Infrastructure:** Establish 1,000 processing and packaging units, with financial assistance of **up to ₹25 lakh per unit,** to strengthen value addition and rural employment.
- **CEFPPC Projects:** Under the **Creation and Expansion of Food Processing and Preservation Capacities (CEFPPC)** component of the **Pradhan Mantri Kisan SAMPADA Yojana (PMKSY)** , **23 pulse processing units** have been approved, of which **18 units have been completed** .
- **Beneficiaries:** Nearly **2 crore farmers are expected to benefit** from assured procurement, improved seeds and enhanced value-chain support.
- **Implementation:** Promote technology adoption, soil-health management, mechanisation and farmer support through the **Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR)** , Krishi Vigyan Kendras (KVKs) and State agricultural departments.



Digital Monitoring and Seed Traceability

- **Three-Tier Monitoring:** A **three-tier Steering Committee mechanism** at the **national, State and district levels** monitors planning, implementation and progress of the Mission.
- **Krishi Mapper:** The **Krishi Mapper application** enables **geo-fencing, land geo-tagging and real-time tracking** of seed-variety demonstrations and crop yields.
- **SATHI Portal:** The **Seed Authentication, Traceability & Holistic Inventory (SATHI) Portal** digitises the **seed supply chain** , covering seed production, certification and sale across the seed life cycle.
- **AgriStack and Digital Crop Survey:** **AgriStack** **and Digital Crop Survey** integrate **Farmer IDs, Soil Health Card** **analytics and verified plot surveys** to support targeted nutrient delivery and more accurate harvest forecasts.
- **E-Samriddhi and Vistaar:** **E-Samriddhi** **and Vistaar** support **direct payments, real-time market information and monitoring of domestic pulse prices** , strengthening transparency and market stability.

India's Pulses Sector

- **Rising Production:** India's pulse production reached **274.09 lakh tonnes in 2025–26 (3rd Advance Estimates)** , up from 256.83 lakh tonnes in 2024–25.
- **Area Expansion:** Pulse cultivation increased to **286.46 lakh hectares in 2025–26** , from 277.20 lakh hectares.
- **Improved Productivity and Trade:** Yield rose to **957 kg/ha from 926 kg/ha** , while import value declined by **31.52%** and export value increased by **13.40%** in 2025–26.
- **Major Pulse-Producing Regions:** Major pulse-growing States include **Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Jharkhand, Odisha and West Bengal** .
- **Major Export Destinations:** Key destinations included **China, UAE, Bangladesh, USA and Sri Lanka**

Conclusion

The **Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses** represents a significant step towards **nutritional security, agricultural self-reliance and farmers' prosperity.** Its long-term success will depend on addressing productivity gaps, strengthening market linkages and promoting climate-resilient farming practices to build a sustainable and import-resilient pulses sector.

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

Q1. Despite being the world's largest producer of pulses, India continues to depend on imports to meet domestic demand. Examine the structural challenges.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. What is the Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses?
It is a six-year government initiative launched on **11 October 2025** to make India self-reliant in pulses by **2030-31** .

Q2. What is the financial outlay of the Mission?
The Mission has an allocation of **₹11,440 crore** for 2025-26 to 2030-31.

Q3. Which pulses are the primary focus of the Mission?
The Mission focuses particularly on **Tur, Urad and Masoor** .

Q4. What is the pulse production target for 2030-31?
The Mission targets nearly **350 lakh tonnes** of pulse production.

Q5. How many pulse processing units are envisaged under the Mission?
The Mission envisages **1,000 pulse processing units** , with **528 units allocated** in the first phase.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/gcKyW8gaIIU]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to pulse production in India, consider the following statements: (2020)

1. Black gram can be cultivated as both kharif and rabi crop.
2. Green gram alone accounts for nearly half of pulse production.
3. In the last three decades, while the production of kharif pulses has increased, the production of rabi pulses has decreased.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 2 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. How has the emphasis on certain crops brought about changes in cropping patterns in recent past? Elaborate the emphasis on millets production and consumption. **(2018)**

Q. What are the present challenges before crop diversification? How do emerging technologies provide an opportunity for crop diversification? **(2021)**

National SC-ST Hub

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **National SC-ST Hub (NSSH)** is strengthening inclusive entrepreneurship by helping **SC/ST-owned Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs)** overcome barriers related to finance, technology,

skills, mentoring and market access.

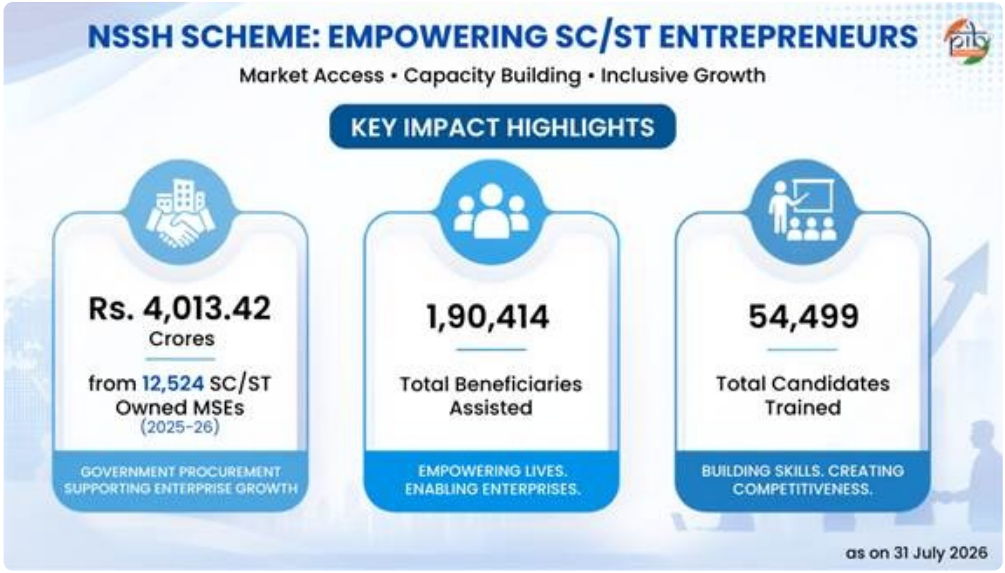
What are the Key Facts About National SC-ST Hub?

- **About:** Launched on 18 October 2016 under the **Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME)** , the National Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe Hub **(NSSH) promotes entrepreneurship** among Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) communities.
- It is implemented through the National Small Industries Corporation (NSIC) .
- **Objective:** Enhance the competitiveness of **SC/ST-owned Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs)** by **improving access** to finance, technology, skills, mentoring and market opportunities, particularly public procurement.
- **Special Credit Linked Capital Subsidy Scheme (SCLCSS):** Supports new and existing **SC/ST-owned MSEs** in upgrading plant, machinery and equipment through a **25% capital subsidy capped at ₹25 lakh** . It covers manufacturing and service enterprises without product or sector restrictions.
- **SCLCSS Progress:** Since 2016 till March 2026, **3,160 MSEs** received **₹356.10 crore** support across **233 districts in 27 States/UTs** .
- **Single Point Registration Scheme (SPRS):** Enables MSEs to access **Government procurement** through NSIC registration, including **free tender sets and EMD exemption** .
- **Public Procurement Support:** Under the Public Procurement Policy, Central Ministries, Departments and CPSEs must procure **25% of annual purchases from MSEs** , including **4% from SC/ST-owned MSEs** .
- **Special Marketing Assistance Scheme (SMAS):** Improves market access and competitiveness through **exhibitions, trade fairs, vendor development programmes, workshops and awareness campaigns** . Enterprises can participate in up to **4 domestic and 2 international events annually** .



Key Achievements of the National SC-ST Hub

- **Procurement Growth:** Procurement from **SC/ST-owned MSEs** increased nearly **39-fold** , from **₹99.37 crore in 2015–16** to **₹4,013.42 crore in 2025–26** .
- **Leading States: Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Assam** emerged as the five leading States under NSSH.
- **Women's Participation: 55% of candidates trained were women** , highlighting the scheme's contribution to inclusive entrepreneurship.
- **Market-Oriented Training:** Training was aligned with **public procurement and GeM opportunities** , covering **cafeteria management and food production, welding, CAD/CAM, laundry services, fashion designing and tailoring, and bamboo-based work** .



What are the Key Support Measures under the National SC-ST Hub?

- **SMAS Financial Support:** International exhibition assistance is capped at **₹3 lakh for micro, ₹2.5 lakh for small and ₹1.5 lakh for medium enterprises** . Enterprises must be registered on the **Udyam Registration Portal and MSME Data Bank** .
- **SMAS Progress in 2025–26: 141 SC/ST MSEs** participated in 4 domestic exhibitions, while **247 vendor development programmes, 197 e-tendering workshops and 230 awareness workshops** were organised.
- **Bank Loan Processing Reimbursement:** Reimburses **80% of loan processing fees or ₹1 lakh, whichever is lower** , excluding taxes, for loans from **Scheduled Commercial Banks, NBFCs and State Finance Corporations** .
- **Bank Guarantee Charges Reimbursement:** Reimburses **80% of eligible Performance Bank Guarantee charges or ₹1 lakh, whichever is lower** , to reduce tender participation costs for SC/ST MSEs.
- **Testing Fee Reimbursement:** Reimburses **80% of eligible testing fees or ₹1 lakh, whichever is lower** , for product testing, licensing and BIS certification through **NABL/BIS-accredited, Government or PSU laboratories** .
- **Export Promotion Council Membership Reimbursement:** Supports **80% of eligible EPC membership charges or ₹20,000, whichever is lower** , including annual membership, subscription and entry fees. Applicants require a valid **IEC and RCMC** .
- **Capacity Building Support:** Provides **90% reimbursement of course fees, up to ₹1 lakh annually** , for 1–30-day programmes at the top 50 **National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF)** management institutes, with up to two courses supported annually. The **Business Accelerator Programme (BAP)** offers mentoring in business strategy, pricing, operational efficiency and market positioning.
- **E-Commerce Market Access:** Supports membership of Government-promoted platforms such as **GeM , e-Khadi , TRIFED , Tribes India and MSME Mart** , with reimbursement of **80% of membership fees or ₹25,000, whichever is lower** .

Conclusion

The National SC-ST Hub **advances inclusive entrepreneurship** and **economic empowerment** by enabling historically marginalised communities to **participate more effectively** in India's industrial economy. Sustained institutional support and stronger market linkages can **promote** employment generation, equitable opportunities and long-term enterprise growth.

Drishti Mains Question:

Q. Examine the challenges faced by Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in India and role of **National SC-ST Hub Scheme to curb them** .

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. What is the National SC-ST Hub?
NSSH is a government initiative focused on strengthening **SC/ST-owned MSEs** through finance, training, technology, mentoring and market access.

Q2. When was NSSH launched?
The National SC-ST Hub was launched on **18 October 2016** .

Q3. Which organisation implements NSSH?
The scheme is implemented through the **National Small Industries Corporation (NSIC)** .

Q4. How much did procurement from SC/ST-owned MSEs increase between 2015-16 and 2025-26?
It increased nearly **39-fold** , from **₹99.37 crore to ₹4,013.42 crore** .

Q5. What is the capital subsidy under SCLCSS?
SCLCSS provides a **25% capital subsidy** , capped at **₹25 lakh** , for eligible investments in plant, machinery and equipment.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Which one of the following categories of Fundamental Rights incorporates protection against untouchability as a form of discrimination? (2020)

(a) Right against Exploitation

(b) Right to Freedom

(c) Right to Constitutional Remedies

(d) Right to Equality

Ans: (d)

Q. If a particular area is brought under the Fifth Schedule of the Constitution of India, which one of the following statements best reflects the consequence of it? (2022)

(a) This would prevent the transfer of land of tribal people to non-tribal people.

(b) This would create a local self-governing body in that area.

(c) This would convert that area into a Union Territory.

(d) The State having such areas would be declared a Special Category State.

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. What are the two major legal initiatives by the State since Independence addressing discrimination against Scheduled Tribes (STs)? **(2017)**

57th GST Council Meeting

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Source: TH

Why in News?

The **57th Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council meeting** , chaired by the Union Finance Minister, approved comprehensive procedural and structural reforms to simplify **GST registration, refunds, input tax credit, exports and litigation** , with most changes expected to take effect from 1 st **April 2027** .

What are the Key Outcomes of the 57th GST Council meeting?

- **GST Rate Rationalisation:** No rate changes were made in the meeting. **GST rate decisions will now be taken once a year** and implemented from the beginning of the subsequent financial year.
- **Simplified Registration:** The Council approved greater certainty regarding documents required for GST registration. **61% of taxpayers currently receive automatic registration within three working days** .
- **Faster refunds:** Refund applications are proposed to be acknowledged within **10 days instead of 15 days** .
- **Inverted duty structure: Input services will become eligible for refunds under the inverted duty structure from 1 st November 2026** .
- **Reduced Litigation:** No GST notices will be issued for tax amounts below **Rs 10,000** , while existing pending notices below this threshold will be withdrawn.
- **Inter-State Movement of Goods:** Goods can be inspected, detained or seized only by officers of the **supplier or destination State** . Interception will require **specific intelligence and authorisation from a Joint Commissioner-level officer** .
- **Decriminalisation:** The Council recommended **removing arrest powers under GST** and raising the **prosecution threshold from Rs 1 crore to Rs 5 crore** .
- **Faceless Assessment:** The Central Government plans to introduce a **faceless assessment system for Central GST** , modelled on the income-tax system. A framework will be released for public consultation before **Budget 2027** , with implementation planned for **2027–28** .
- **Service exports:** Services provided by an Indian company to a foreign client through its **overseas branch** can qualify for export benefits.
  - Testing, repair, certification and research conducted in India for foreign clients may also qualify as **exports of services even when the goods remain in India** .
- **Overall significance:** The reforms seek to improve **ease of doing business, tax certainty,**

compliance efficiency, movement of goods and taxpayer trust , while reducing unnecessary litigation and enforcement.

What are the Key Facts About the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council?

- **About:** The **GST Council is a constitutional body established under Article 279A through the 101 st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2016** , responsible for recommending policies to create a harmonised GST regime and a unified national market.
- **Composition:** Chaired by the **Union Finance Minister** and includes the **Union Minister of State for Finance/Revenue** and **State Finance or Taxation Ministers** .
- **Key Function:** Makes recommendations on **GST rates, exemptions, threshold limits, model GST laws, place of supply and principles for apportionment of IGST** .
- **Petroleum Products:** Under **Article 279A(5)** , the Council recommends the date from which GST may be levied on **petroleum crude, diesel, petrol, natural gas and aviation turbine fuel** .
- **Quorum: At least 50% of the total members** must be present for a meeting to constitute a quorum.
- **Voting:** Decisions require a **3/4th weighted majority** of members present and voting. The **Centre has 1/3rd weightage** , while **States collectively have 2/3rd weightage** .
- **Cooperative Federalism:** The GST Council is a key institution of **Centre-State fiscal cooperation** , bringing both levels of government together for GST policymaking.

Goods and Services Tax

- **About:** The **GST** is a **destination-based, value-added indirect tax** introduced through the **101 st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2016** , aimed at creating a **unified national market and simplifying India’s indirect tax system** .
  - GST subsumes several Central and State taxes, including **Central Excise Duty, Service Tax, VAT, Central Sales Tax and Luxury Tax** , and is levied on the **supply of goods and services** .
  - India follows a **dual GST model** , under which the Centre levies **CGST** and States levy **SGST** on intra-State supplies, while **IGST** is levied on inter-State supplies and imports along with applicable customs duties.
- **Goods and Services Tax Network (GSTN)** : It provides the technology backbone for GST registration, return filing, e-invoicing and compliance.
- **Next-Generation GST reforms (GST 2.0)** : Approved by the **56th GST Council meeting in 2025** , sought to simplify the GST rate structure, reduce the compliance burden and improve tax administration.
  - The reforms streamlined GST mainly into **5% and 18% tax slabs** , while introducing a **40% GST rate for specified luxury and sin goods** such as tobacco products, certain high-end vehicles, yachts and private aircraft.
  - They also provide **consumer and household relief through lower GST rates and exemptions on selected essential goods, medicines and insurance** , while supporting **MSMEs, startups, manufacturers and artisans** through lower taxation on key inputs and sectors such as cement and handicrafts.
  - At the administrative level, GST is increasingly becoming **technology-driven through GSTN, e-invoicing, pre-filled returns, real-time data validation, Artificial Intelligence AI, Machine Learning ML and data analytics** , helping improve compliance, reduce errors, detect tax evasion and strengthen India’s indirect tax administration.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the constitutional basis of the GST Council?
The GST Council is a constitutional body under Article 279A, created through the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2016.

2. What are the major outcomes of the 57th GST Council meeting?
Key reforms include faster refunds, simplified registration, reduced litigation, restrictions on GST enforcement, service-export reforms and faceless Central GST assessment.

3. How does the GST Council follow cooperative federalism?
The Council includes Union and State representatives, with 1/3rd voting weight for the Centre and 2/3rd for States, requiring a 3/4th weighted majority for decisions.

4. What is GST 2.0?
GST 2.0 refers to the Next-Generation GST reforms aimed at simplifying the tax structure, reducing compliance costs and strengthening technology-driven tax administration.

5. What is the significance of the faceless GST assessment system?
The proposed faceless Central GST assessment aims to reduce direct interaction, improve transparency and consistency, and minimise scope for arbitrary tax administration.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/ydviZZqw5ts**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. What is/are the most likely advantages of implementing 'Goods and Services Tax (GST)'? (2017)

1. It will replace multiple taxes collected by multiple authorities and will thus create a single market in India.
2. It will drastically reduce the 'Current Account Deficit' of India and will enable it to increase its foreign exchange reserves.
3. It will enormously increase the growth and size of the economy of India and will enable it to overtake China in the near future.

Select the correct answer using the code given below

(a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. Explain the rationale behind the Goods and Services Tax (Compensation to States) Act of 2017. How has COVID-19 impacted the GST compensation fund and created new federal tensions? **(2020)**

Navi Pillay Awarded Nobel Peace Prize 2026

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Source: TH

South African jurist and human rights champion of Indian descent (Tamil Nadu), Navanethem “Navi” Pillay, was named the recipient of the 2026 **Nobel Peace Prize** . However, the historic announcement was immediately overshadowed by a major geopolitical development.

- Hours after the award was announced, the United States imposed sweeping economic sanctions on the **International Criminal Court (ICC)** , an institution where Pillay formerly served as a judge.
- **2026 Nobel Peace Prize Laureate:** Navi Pillay, a South African jurist of **Indian Tamil ancestry** , pioneered anti-apartheid legal advocacy and contributed to international criminal jurisprudence.
  - As a judge of the **International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda (ICTR)** , she contributed to landmark jurisprudence recognising **rape and sexual violence as acts of genocide** , particularly in the **Akayesu case (1998)** .
  - She subsequently served as a judge at the **International Criminal Court (ICC)** , as the **UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (2008–2014)** and as an **ad hoc judge at the International Court of Justice (ICJ)** in the Rohingya genocide case concerning Myanmar.
  - She also chaired the **UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory (2021–2025)** .
  - Navi Pillay became the **first South African woman** and the fifth South African overall to win the Nobel Peace Prize, joining laureates such as **Nelson Mandela** and Desmond Tutu.
- **US Sanctions on the International Criminal Court (ICC):** The US administration imposed comprehensive economic penalties targeting ICC officials and service vendors (telecom and software providers), citing resistance against the tribunal exercising jurisdiction over citizens of non-member states.
- **ICC:** Established by the **Rome Statute of 1998** (in force since **2002**) with headquarters at **The Hague, Netherlands** , the ICC functions as an independent permanent court prosecuting **genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and the crime of aggression** .
- **Principle of Complementarity:** The ICC operates strictly as a **"court of last resort,"** stepping in only when domestic legal systems are unwilling or unable to genuinely carry out proceedings.
- **State Party Status and India's Stand:** While the ICC comprises **125 member states** , major powers including the **US, China, and Russia** are not parties.
  - **India is not a party to the Rome Statute** , citing state sovereignty concerns, the non-inclusion of certain weapons categories, and the overarching powers given to the **UN Security Council** .



Read more: 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine: Optogenetics

- **Nobel Prize in Chemistry 2026: Non-Linear Effects & Autocatalysis**
- **Nobel Prize in Physics 2026: IceCube Neutrino Observatory**
- **2026 Nobel Prize in Literature**

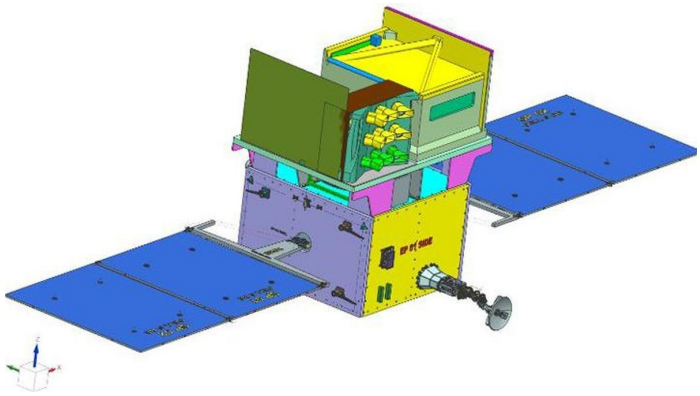
TRISHNA Satellite

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Source: TH

The Indo-French **TRISHNA (Thermal Infra-Red Imaging Satellite for High-resolution Natural Resource Assessment) mission** has entered an advanced stage of development, with ISRO expecting its launch within the next 12–16 months.

- **About:** TRISHNA is a joint Earth-observation mission of the **Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)** and France's National Centre for Space Studies (CNES), aimed at high-resolution monitoring of Earth's surface temperature, water resources and ecosystem dynamics.
- **Objective:** It will provide high spatial and temporal resolution data on surface temperature, emissivity, biophysical variables and radiation to support surface energy-budget assessment and sustainable natural resource management.
- **Applications:** The satellite will help monitor agricultural water use, irrigation efficiency, crop water stress, evapotranspiration, drought conditions, urban heat islands and ecosystem health, supporting climate studies and water-resource planning.
- **Payloads:** The satellite will carry two primary payloads:
  - **Thermal Infra-Red (TIR):** Developed by CNES, France, to measure Earth's surface thermal emissions.
  - **Visible-Near Infra-Red and Short-Wave Infra-Red (VNIR-SWIR):** Developed by ISRO, to observe surface characteristics and vegetation conditions.
- **Launch Vehicle:** TRISHNA is planned to be launched using India's Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) .
- **India–France Cooperation:** TRISHNA is the third joint satellite mission following Megha-Tropiques and SARAL. ISRO is responsible for the satellite bus and VNIR-SWIR payload, while CNES provides the TIR payload. Scientific data will be processed jointly by India and France .



Read more: **Strategic Evolution of India-France Relations**

JOSH Teams Launched for TB Elimination

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Source: PIB

Recently, the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare** has launched **JOSH (Joint Squad for Health) Teams** under the **TB Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan at** Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, to strengthen youth-led community participation in TB elimination.

- **Youth-Led Action:** JOSH Teams will mobilise **MY Bharat Volunteers and NCC Cadets** to promote **TB prevention, early diagnosis, timely treatment, treatment adherence and stigma reduction** at the grassroots.
- **Grassroots Outreach:** Teams will undertake **household and community interactions** , identify people with TB symptoms, encourage testing, support treatment completion and address myths, misconceptions and discrimination.
- **Scale of Initiative:** In the first phase, teams have been deployed in **55 districts across 11 States and Union Territories** , with nationwide expansion planned.
- **Institutional Convergence:** The initiative brings together the **Ministries of Health and Family Welfare, Youth Affairs and Sports, and Defence** , promoting a **whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach** to TB elimination.
- **2030 Goal:** JOSH Teams seek to accelerate India's efforts towards **TB elimination before 2030** by strengthening **Jan Bhagidari, youth participation and last-mile community engagement** .
- **TB Progress:** India has recorded a **21% decline in TB incidence** , compared with a **12% global decline** , while TB treatment coverage has increased to **92%** , compared with **78% globally** .
- **TB Mukt Panchayats:** In 2026, **67,933 Panchayats across 697 districts** were recognised as **TB Mukt** , reflecting increased community-level participation in TB prevention and control.
- **Technology for TB Control:** India is using **AI-supported portable X-ray systems and rapid molecular diagnostic technologies** to strengthen early detection and identify drug resistance.
- **Digital Support:** The **JOSH Flipbook, JOSH Brochure, Khushi Avatar e-Sangini service** (available in 12 Indian languages) and a dedicated JOSH Teams feature on the TB Mukt Bharat App were launched to strengthen awareness, treatment adherence and community engagement.

Read More: World Tuberculosis Day 2026

National Conclave on Tribal Rights

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Source : **PIB**

The Ministry of Tribal Affairs organised the National Conclave on **“Constitutional Rights and Legal Provisions for Tribal Communities”** at SCOPE Complex, New Delhi.

- **Objective:** Identify difficulties faced by tribal communities in accessing constitutional rights and develop practical recommendations through field-level feedback and sharing of best practices.
- **Constitutional Provisions**
  - **Articles 15(4) and 16(4):** Enable special provisions and reservation for STs in education and public employment.
  - **Article 19(5):** Permits restrictions to protect the interests of Scheduled Tribes.
  - **Article 29:** Safeguards the distinct language, script and culture of communities, including tribal groups.
  - **Article 46:** Directs the State to promote STs’ educational and economic interests and protect them from social injustice and exploitation.
  - **Article 342:** Specifies Scheduled Tribes in relation to particular States or Union Territories.
  - **Article 338A:** Establishes the NCST to monitor safeguards and investigate complaints regarding tribal-rights deprivation.
  - **Fifth Schedule:** Provides for Scheduled Areas, Tribal Advisory Councils and safeguards over tribal land and administration.
- **Legal Provisions:**
  - **Forest Rights Act, 2006:** Recognises individual and community forest rights and addresses historical injustice.
  - **PESA Act, 1996:** Strengthens Gram Sabhas’ role in self-governance, resources and development in Scheduled Areas.
  - **SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989** : Protects STs against atrocities, discrimination and exploitation.

Read More: **Tribal Development Approaches**